

CHAPTER 12 — Home

“Day five,” Zoe said, “started the night before. When I knocked on my own front door.”

Elias glanced at her in the mirror, then back to the motorway.

A lorry behind them indicated for several seconds before moving into the slow lane. The ticking reached them faintly through the glass, regular and patient, until the vehicle dropped away.

“I thought getting home would fix everything,” Zoe said. “That was the part I didn’t understand. Not how wrong I was. Why.”

Elias did not tell her that children were supposed to believe in home. He did not tell her that the belief was reasonable, or that losing it was not her fault.

Those were all true things.

None of them would have changed what happened when the door opened.

The porch light was on.

Helen always turned it off before evening had properly settled, because leaving it burning when nobody needed it was, in her words, the same as feeding coins into the wall. Zoe had heard the complaint so often she could repeat the exact sigh that came before it.

Now the light shone over the step and the leaning plant pot Helen had been promising to replace since spring.

Zoe knocked.

The door opened before she could do it a second time.

Helen stood there in slippers and the blue cardigan she wore when the house was cold. For one second she simply stared. Her face seemed unable to decide what expression belonged on it.

Then she made a sound that was not quite Zoe’s name and pulled her inside.

The embrace was real.

Zoe knew that because Helen held too tightly and because her breath broke against Zoe's hair. She smelled of lavender detergent, hand cream and the onions she had been chopping for dinner. Familiar smells. Safe smells. The kind Zoe had tried to remember in the locked bedroom when the television would not stop talking through the wall.

Her knees almost gave way.

Helen felt it and tightened her grip.

"Oh, sweetheart. Oh, God."

For a few seconds Zoe let herself believe she had reached the end of it.

Then Helen pulled back.

Her hands moved over Zoe's face, her shoulders, the sleeves of the cleaned uniform, checking without quite knowing what she was checking for. Relief remained in her expression, but something else had entered it.

Something sharper.

Her eyes moved past Zoe towards the street.

Brian appeared behind her.

He did not come forward. He looked over Zoe's head, first towards the gate, then the parked cars, then the dark hedge along the neighbour's drive.

"Did anyone see you come in?" he asked.

Zoe stared at him.

"Brian," Helen said.

"Did anyone follow you?"

"I don't know."

He stepped outside far enough to look both ways along the road. The porch light fell across his face. Zoe could see the small muscle near his temple moving while he counted windows, cars, people who were not there.

"Inside," he said. "Quickly."

Helen drew Zoe farther into the hallway. Brian closed the door, turned the lock, fitted the chain and then checked the lock again.

It was an old habit.

He checked doors twice before bed, pressed the car key twice after parking and always went back to make sure the cooker was off, even when Helen had used it.

Until that night Zoe had thought it was simply one of the things that made him Brian.

He reached past her and switched off the porch light.

The hallway went dark.

The house had not changed.

That was the first thing that made it feel wrong.

Her school photograph still stood on the narrow table beneath the mirror, one corner hidden behind a bowl full of keys. A pencil mark inside the cupboard door recorded the year she had grown three inches and Brian had accused the tape measure of lying. Helen's ceramic hedgehog sat on the windowsill, the one Zoe had made when she was seven and which looked nothing like a hedgehog unless somebody explained it first.

Her shoes were still beneath the radiator where she had kicked them off four days earlier.

Everything had waited for her.

Helen led her into the kitchen and sat her at the table. The smell of onions had begun to catch in the pan. Helen turned off the hob without looking at it.

"Are you hurt?"

The question came so late Zoe nearly did not recognise it for what it was.

"I don't know."

Helen crouched in front of her. There were tears drying on her face now, but she kept pushing Zoe's hair back from her forehead as if the right arrangement of it might make the last four days less real.

"Did they—"

She stopped.

The unfinished question hung between them.

Zoe looked down at her hands.

"They kept me in a room."

Helen covered her mouth.

Brian had gone to the front window. He moved the curtain aside by the width of two fingers, looked out, let it fall, then checked the back door.

"We should call the police," Helen said.

Brian turned.

"And tell them what?"

"That she's home. That she was taken."

"And when they ask where she came from? When they ask for papers? Names? Dates?"

Helen stood slowly.

"She's been missing for four days."

"I know how long she's been missing."

"Then act like it."

Brian's face changed, not into anger exactly, but into the expression he wore when a bill arrived that he had been expecting and still could not afford.

"We call Mac again," he said.

Zoe's head lifted.

Mac was the man she had always been taught to call Uncle Mac. He

sent birthday money through Helen and telephoned at Christmas from whichever city he happened to be in. There were photographs of him, but never many, and never the kind where everybody stood close enough to touch.

He belonged to the family story in the way distant relatives often did: accepted because adults had always spoken as though there was nothing to question.

Helen shook her head once.

“Not yet. She needs a doctor. She needs sleep.”

“We call him now.”

Something in Brian’s voice ended the argument.

Zoe had heard him use that voice with delivery drivers and once with a man who reversed into their garden wall. She had never heard him use it with Helen.

He took his phone from his pocket and left the kitchen.

Helen watched him go.

Then she looked at the backpack still looped around Zoe’s shoulders.

“Let me take that, love.”

Zoe’s hands closed around the straps.

“No.”

Helen stopped.

The answer had come out harder than Zoe intended. For a moment they both seemed surprised by it.

“It’s only your school things,” Helen said gently.

“I said no.”

Helen’s gaze moved over Zoe’s face. Whatever she saw there made her lower her hands.

“All right.”

She did not ask again.

That small surrender frightened Zoe almost as much as Brian checking the street.

Helen made toast because it was the only food Zoe could keep down. She cut it diagonally, the way she had when Zoe was small, and spread too much butter near the edges.

Zoe managed half a slice.

The scrape of Helen's knife against the plate made her think of the metal spoon touching the glass of sedative. A car door closed outside and her whole body went rigid before she could stop it.

Brian noticed.

He crossed to the front window again.

"It's next door," he said after checking. "Just next door."

He sounded irritated, but not with her.

That almost made it worse.

Helen brought a bowl of warm water and cleaned the scrape along Zoe's wrist. Her touch was careful. She murmured apologies whenever Zoe flinched, though she had not caused the injury.

For a while she was simply Helen again: the woman who sat beside Zoe through fevers, who saved wrapping paper if it had not torn, who could identify which cupboard door had been left open from another room.

Then Brian returned with the phone in his hand.

"He's coming in the morning."

Helen's fingers stopped around the cloth.

"Here?"

"He said nobody was to call anyone until he got here."

"Brian—"

"He knows what this is."

Zoe looked from one of them to the other.

"Knows what what is?"

Neither answered.

Brian put the phone face down on the table.

"You can't go near the windows," he said. "You can't call school. You can't call Jackie. No messages, no social media, nothing that tells anyone you're here."

"Why?"

"Because the people who took you may be looking for you."

It was the first answer that sounded like protection.

Zoe wanted to accept it. She wanted so badly to accept it that for several seconds she almost did.

Then she remembered Brian's first question at the door.

Not what happened?

Not are you hurt?

Did anyone see you?

"How does Mac know?" she asked.

Brian picked up the phone again.

"Go upstairs."

"How does he know what this is?"

"Zoe."

Helen touched her shoulder.

Zoe recoiled before she could stop herself.

Helen removed her hand as though burned.

Nobody spoke after that.

Her bedroom was exactly as she had left it.

The duvet was turned back from the morning she disappeared. A school jumper lay over the chair. Glow-in-the-dark stars still clung to the ceiling, though most had lost their light years ago. On the shelf above her desk stood a row of photographs: Zoe and Helen on a beach, Brian holding a collapsed tent pole while Zoe laughed, Jackie pulling a face behind a birthday cake.

There was so much proof that she belonged there that the room seemed to be trying too hard.

Zoe locked the door.

The old lock was meant for privacy, not security. Brian could open it with a coin. Still, the click helped.

She took off the backpack and placed it on the bed.

For several minutes she only looked at it.

The folder was inside. So was the black drive. Two objects from a room that should not have existed, resting among exercise books and a pencil case with a broken zip.

She considered opening the folder.

She could not.

Not in that room. Not with Helen moving downstairs and Brian speaking in low bursts into his phone. Not while some part of her still believed that whatever was written inside might destroy the only version of home she had left.

She closed the backpack and pushed it beneath the bed, behind a plastic storage box filled with old school projects. The ceramic mask she had made at nine stared up from the box through a sheet of tissue paper, one eye larger than the other.

Then Zoe sat on the floor with her back against the bed.

From downstairs came the sound of cupboards opening, the kettle filling and Brian checking the front door for the third time.

She had imagined home as the place where she would finally be allowed to stop watching.

Instead, everybody else had started watching too.

That night she woke three times.

The first time, she thought the television from the trafficking house was playing beyond the wall.

The second, she heard footsteps on the landing and crawled silently from the bed before recognising Helen's soft slippers.

The third time, voices carried through the heating vent.

Zoe lay still.

Helen and Brian were in the kitchen. They spoke carefully, believing the closed doors and running boiler would hide them.

"We can't keep her here if they know she's back."

"Where else is she supposed to go?"

"That's for him to decide."

"She's not a parcel."

A pause.

Then Brian, quieter: "That's not how they see it."

Zoe pulled the duvet closer around herself.

Helen said something she could not hear.

Brian answered, "The money won't matter if this comes out. None of it will."

"Don't talk about that now."

"When, then? When the police ask why there was no proper adoption? When they ask who arranged it?"

Zoe stopped breathing.

Helen's voice dropped so low that Zoe caught only pieces.

We raised her.

Doesn't change—

She is ours.

Brian made a sound with no humour in it.

“Tell that to Mac.”

The boiler clicked off.

Silence filled the vent.

Then Helen said, “She'll hear you.”

Not she's frightened.

Not she needs us.

She'll hear.

Zoe stared into the darkness until the stars above her bed slowly appeared, faint green points holding their shape long after they should have stopped glowing.

Mac arrived before nine the next morning.

He came alone in a dark car that looked recently washed. Brian opened the door before he knocked.

Zoe heard his voice from the landing.

Calm. Ordinary. The voice of a man asking whether a delivery had arrived on time.

Helen and Brian became quiet around it.

Zoe sat at the top of the stairs with her knees pulled to her chest and watched through the banister.

Mac removed his coat and handed it to nobody. He folded it once over his arm before entering the living room.

He was not physically imposing, and nothing about him demanded attention. His suit was dark without being expensive enough to notice, his hair neat, his face the kind a person could pass in a corridor and fail to remember ten seconds later.

Even seated in Helen's living room, he seemed designed to leave no strong impression behind.

"Where is she?" he asked.

Helen looked towards the stairs.

Mac followed her eyes.

For an instant his gaze met Zoe's through the wooden rails.

He smiled.

It was a relative's smile. Practised, restrained and entirely wrong for the room.

"There you are," he said. "Come down, Zoe. We need to talk."

She remained where she was.

Brian shifted his weight.

Mac did not repeat himself. He simply waited.

Eventually Zoe stood and descended, keeping one hand against the wall because the floor still moved unexpectedly beneath her.

Mac's gaze touched the hand she kept against the wall and moved on.

They sat in the living room. Helen took the armchair beside Zoe. Brian remained standing until Mac looked at him, then sat as well.

Mac placed both hands on one knee.

"Tell me how you got away."

Zoe looked at Helen.

Helen's eyes were red from the night before.

"A door was open," Zoe said.

"Which door?"

"At the back."

"Why was it open?"

"People were fighting."

"Who?"

"I don't know."

"What were they fighting about?"

Zoe felt the folder beneath the bed as clearly as if it were still pressed against her spine.

"I don't know."

Mac studied her for a moment.

He did not accuse her of lying. He moved to the next question.

"Did you speak to anyone after you left?"

"A bus driver."

Helen inhaled sharply.

"What did you tell him?" Mac asked.

"Nothing. He let me on because I was in uniform."

"Anyone else?"

"No."

"Did you go near your school?"

"The bus went past it."

"Did you get off?"

"No."

For the first time, something like approval crossed his face.

"Good."

The word made Zoe feel ill.

Mac turned to Helen and Brian.

"No police. No social services. No hospital unless I arrange it. What have you told the school?"

"Family emergency," Brian said. "Since Wednesday."

"Keep it that way. Nobody tells them she has returned. Nobody outside this house learns she is here."

Helen gripped the arm of her chair.

"She needs medical attention."

"Then I will arrange someone discreet."

"She needs people she knows."

"The people who took her know the people she knows. That is precisely the problem."

His tone did not change. He spoke as though explaining a simple mistake in a timetable.

Brian leaned forward.

"How long?"

"Until she can be moved."

Zoe looked at him.

"Moved where?"

Mac's attention returned to her.

"Somewhere safer."

"Where?"

"With family."

"What family?"

A pause, brief enough that Helen and Brian might not have noticed it.

Zoe did.

"My mother," Mac said. "Your grandmother."

“Helen said I didn’t have one.”

Helen’s face changed.

Mac smiled again, but less of it reached his eyes this time.

“Families are complicated.”

“That’s not an answer.”

Brian said her name in warning.

Mac raised one finger without looking at him.

Brian fell silent.

The gesture was small.

Its effect was not.

“You have had a terrible experience,” Mac said. “You are exhausted, frightened and surrounded by information you do not yet understand. I am trying to keep you alive long enough for that to change.”

Every word could have been true.

Zoe still did not believe him.

“Why do they listen to you?” she asked.

Helen closed her eyes.

Mac’s expression remained mild.

“Because I know what happens next.”

He stood.

The conversation was over because he had decided it was.

At the doorway he turned back to Zoe.

“Do not contact your friend Jackie. Not for any reason.”

Zoe’s face gave her away before she could stop it.

Mac noticed.

Of course he noticed.

"This is not punishment," he said. "It is protection."

Then he left the room.

Helen cried in the kitchen after Mac drove away.

Not loudly. Helen had always cried as though apologising for the inconvenience of it, wiping each tear before the next one could fall.

Brian stood beside her with one hand on her shoulder.

"Hold it together," he said. The words were firm, but his thumb moved once across the fabric of her cardigan. "Just until this is done. Then we can fall apart."

Zoe watched from the doorway.

Helen saw her first.

For a moment none of them moved.

Then Helen reached towards her.

Zoe stepped back.

The hurt on Helen's face was immediate and genuine.

That was almost unbearable.

"Zoe," she said.

"Why didn't you call the police when I disappeared?"

Brian looked at the floor.

Helen's hand lowered.

"We called Mac when you didn't come home."

"Before the police?"

Helen looked down.

The silence answered.

“Did you look for me?”

“Every day.”

“How?”

Helen opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

Zoe looked at Brian.

“Did you?”

His jaw worked once.

“We did what we could without making it worse.”

“For who?”

The question seemed to empty the kitchen.

Brian turned away first.

Helen sat down at the table and covered her face.

Nobody asked Zoe what had happened inside the house. Not properly. They asked whether she had been seen, whether she had spoken, whether she had brought attention back with her.

They measured danger by how close it had come to their door.

That was when Zoe first understood that protection and management could use the same locks, the same lowered voices and the same order to stay inside.

From the outside they could look identical.

From within, only one of them cared what happened to the person behind the door.

Elias kept his hands light on the wheel.

Anger would have been easier. What settled in him was colder and more deliberate.

“They weren’t protecting you,” he said.

"No."

"Helen might have believed she was."

Zoe looked at him in the mirror.

"Does that make it better?"

"No."

The answer came without hesitation.

She looked away.

"I think she loved me," Zoe said. "I think Brian did too, in whatever way he knew how. That's the part that makes it worse. If none of it was real, I could throw the whole thing away. But some of it was. I just don't know which parts."

Elias drove for several seconds before speaking.

"You may never get one clean answer."

"I know."

"That doesn't mean you imagined the good parts."

Zoe said nothing.

The motorway barrier flashed silver beside them, post after post, each one appearing and vanishing before it could be studied.

"Mac told me not to contact Jackie," Zoe said eventually. "That made me think about something she'd told me before."

Her voice had changed. Softer now, carrying the shape of somebody remembered before the memory became dangerous.

"She collected stories. Rumours, things adults said when they forgot children were listening. I never knew where she got half of them, and she liked not telling me. Made her feel mysterious."

A small smile appeared and disappeared.

"There was one she said people in Mac's world still talked about years later. Like a ghost story, except nobody believed in the ghost until they

had to.”

Elias’s eyes remained on the road.

“Two crews were starting a war,” Zoe continued. “Fighting over territory that used to belong to Mac before either crew existed. Somebody sent a watcher in. Just gather intelligence. Watch, listen, report back. Don’t interfere.”

The traffic ahead slowed. Elias eased off the accelerator earlier than necessary.

“Then both crews decided the watcher belonged to the other side. They came for him on the same night, from different directions. Jackie said they thought they were killing each other’s advantage.”

Zoe watched the back of Elias’s head.

“She said the watcher was the only one who walked out. Every person from both crews was gone. And afterwards, the watcher never reported back. No body. No confirmation. Just disappeared with everybody else left behind him.”

Elias changed lanes.

The movement was smooth, but he checked the empty mirror twice.

“Jackie knew the date,” Zoe said. “She said people remembered it even if they never said why.”

She told him.

For less than a second, the engine note softened.

Elias corrected immediately.

He did not turn around.

“Interesting story,” he said.

His voice was level enough to sound rehearsed.

Zoe studied him.

“You’ve heard it before.”

Elias kept his gaze on the grey road ahead.

He did not answer.

He did not need to.